

Perfect Gifts



KENNY WRIGHT
A SHORT

Perfect Gifts

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1.

“Oh...Jacque!”

I woke with a start, disoriented and still half-asleep. It was still dark. Still just...5:44, my clock read in dull green. I shut my eyes, sleep already coiling around me when I heard it again.

A moan. A female moan. And—

“Yes...there...”

This time, when I opened my eyes, I was wide awake. I turned to my wife, expecting...I’m not sure what I was expecting. She always maintained that she didn’t play with herself, but—

“Uh!”

Annalise was on her back, her eyes closed, but not shut tight. Her hands clutched her blanket to her chest, but weren’t down between her legs. She was sleeping. Dreaming. Dreaming of—

“Jacque!”

Jacque? Or Jack? Not that I knew someone named either. Apparently Annalise did, and wanted to know him really well. Or maybe she did already?

The question arrived with a powerful thud. I looked at Annalise. There was just enough streetlight filtering in through our curtains that I could make out her delicate beauty. Her bow-like lips were parted in another, quiet gasp, her brow furrowed beneath the sweep of her blond hair. Unable to help myself, I reached out, running my fingers along her cheek. She sighed, nuzzling against my touch, but not waking.

Beneath her eyelids, her eyes darted, lost in her racy dream—her dream of “Jacque.”

I dreamt along with her, imagining this other man taking her. It was a fantasy that I’d secretly harbored for a long time, so it was an easy thing to imagine. She was on her back, as she was now, legs spread around him as he drove his cock deep into her. Her hand grabbed the man’s shoulder to steady herself, to encourage more. He’d never had a face, but now he had a name.

Watching Annalise dream my fantasy was too much. I was so hard. So excited. I ran my hand down her neck. She was wearing a long, cotton

nightgown that clung to her soft breasts. I could feel her nipples, stiff and excited through the thin material. She reacted to my touch, moaning a little louder, but still didn't wake.

I moved beneath the blankets, pushing her nightgown up to bare her thighs, her pussy. It was dark enough that I couldn't see anything, but I didn't need to. I parted her knees and crawled in between her legs.

Annalise was beautiful, blonde and buxom and sweet looking. She had a dimpled smile and a Southern accent, the kind of woman most would imagine twirling a frilly parasol before doing anything naughty. And they were mostly right. She was sweet and kind, loved animals and giggled at jokes. Very few people ever caught a glimpse of her sexual side, but that was what made it sexier.

I could smell her excitement, and when I brushed my thumb along her pussy—shaved bare as always—she was as wet as I'd ever seen her. I followed with my mouth, lapping her smooth, puffy lips. She shifted above me, waking, perhaps? Her legs parted and I moved in closer, darting my tongue exactly the way she liked it.

"Ahh..." she groaned, louder, more alert. A moment later, I felt her hands in my hair. The dream was over, but I wondered if she still held the image of Jacque in her head. I hoped so.

In my fantasies, this strange man would discover this other side of her, this dirtier side, just as I had five years ago. That memory was still one of the most powerful for me—and probably exactly why I had the fantasy that I did.

It was college. We were in our junior year. We'd been dating, but we weren't exclusive. Mostly, though, I thought that meant that I got to see other people. I never even considered that sweet Annalise would date around. Then I walked in on her with another man.

It was late. I'd been at a party, but wasn't feeling it. It may have been the first time that I realized that I'd rather be with Annalise than without her. So I left the party and wandered drunkenly to her dorm. I got in through the front door as another set of coeds were on their way out. I took the stairs two at a time, excited to see Annalise's warm smile—and even more excited to taste her sweet lips.

I didn't even think to knock. I should have. It wasn't like we were at that point in our relationship where we shared a key or anything, but I was

just so exuberant—like shout-from-the-rooftops level. So I opened the door and saw them.

To this day, my heart skips at the memory. Annalise was on her back, her pale, white legs wrapped around Terrance Cole's very black body. I can still hear her moans. Still remember the way she drove her hips up to meet his hard thrusts.

I remember feeling sick with jealousy, and yet so, amazingly, profoundly turned on.

"Uh, uhh..." Annalise's moans, past and present, entwined. I worked her pussy, tonguing tight circles around her clit as I fingered her.

There had always been things that didn't quite match up to the sweet girl that Annalise projected—how she preferred frilly lingerie over more utilitarian cotton, how she kept her pussy bare, how skilled she was at sucking cock. I'd just never put it all together until I walked in on her and Terrance. And then I couldn't stop thinking about it.

"I need...I need..." She couldn't quite form the words, but she didn't need to. I gave one last, shudder-inducing suck on her clit before moving up her body, pulling my boxers down as I did so. Emerging from beneath the sweltering blankets, I breathed the fresh, cool air of morning.

Annalise still had her eyes closed, her long lashes fanning out on her pale cheeks. I never kissed her just after going down on her, afraid of how she'd react to her own taste, but I always thought of it. Would Terrance have shown as much concern? Would Jacques?

Annalise's faceless lover was back once again. My erection surged. I buried my head in Annalise's neck, kissing and nuzzling the soft skin. My hands found hers, our fingers lacing as I pinned them above her on the mattress. That's how Terrance had fucked her, and this was the closest I ever got to taking her as dominantly as he had.

One of the things that made Annalise so sexy in bed was how into it she sounded. She moaned and cried, she gasped, she panted hard when she was close. As I moved in and out of her, she was panting hard. She was close. She rarely spoke...to me.

Fuck me, big boy. I still remember hearing it, an order issued to Terrance in the moments before he came. *Fuck me, big boy.* I heard it now, early in morning in bed, years later. He was big. She wanted to get *fucked*. I imagined I was him. I tightened my grip on her hands. I drove my hips

faster, harder, feeling my balls swing against her ass. She opened her legs wider, accepting me, accepting the fuck.

She threw her head back. I felt the muscles in her neck tighten. I heard her moan well up from deep inside of her. She bowed up, her full tits surging against me as her orgasm crashed through her—through us. I came with her, my mind awash with her giving in to other men, faceless men, strangers who fantasized about her from across the room.

We came down from our high, sweaty and spent. I rolled onto my back beside her, pushing the comforter away. Annalise turned to me, snuggling against me.

Her voice was as warm as her body. “What time is it?”

“Early,” I said, out of breath. We hadn’t had sex so vigorously in a while and I was out of practice.

“Well, good morning to you, too,” Annalise said with a chuckle. “What a great way to wake up.”

I thought about what had woken *me* up—“Jacque.” My heart started racing all over again as I considered asking who he was. Would she blush? Would she get defensive? Or would she dispel the illusion that he was a threat at all. *Oh, Jacque works at the Starbucks near the school. Or, that’s funny, Jacque was a guy I knew back in high school.*

In that quiet moment, in the post-sex haze of the early morning, I decided that not knowing was actually sexier than knowing. The logic was flawed, but the risks were low. In our three years of marriage, I’d never had reason to question her fidelity. Hearing her dream about some random guy wasn’t a reason to start questioning it now. And deep down, I preferred that she kept the crush a secret. It was easier that way. I had the aftermath of the Terrance incident to remind me of that.

2.

Annalise kissed me as she got out of bed. I checked the clock again. It wasn't even six. I rolled over and tried to find sleep as the shower cut on. She normally got up around 6:30, whereas my usual wake-up was closer to 8—one of many benefits of working from home.

I shut my eyes, but sleep wouldn't come. Instead, I heard Annalise moaning another man's name, heard her gasps and cries. *Fuck me, big boy.*

Fuck me. I turned again as the water cut off and she emerged, scrubbed clean, a towel wrapped around her pale body. I watched her move about the room. She modestly slipped into her thong before dropping the towel. I admired her backside, creamy and graceful, as she hooked a matching bra on. There was nothing fancy about the lingerie, soft white with a few lace flourishes, but it was still alluring enough to make me wonder how I could take her sexuality for granted.

She floated over to her closet, humming softly to herself as she sifted through her outfits. The act was so mundane, yet for whatever reason, I was focused on every detail. She'd pull a skirt out, appraise it for a couple seconds, then put it back before selecting another. Was she always this deliberative when she got dressed? Or was she thinking of dressing for someone in particular?

My stomach twisted into a knot. I continued to watch.

At last, she selected a pair of white pants and a white, turtleneck sweater. It was a combo she wore often in the winter, and always looked good on her. When she fixed her blond hair into a high, tight bun, she was a wet dream for all the high school boys in her history class, and somehow I'd landed her.

She disappeared into the bathroom again to brush her teeth and fix her makeup. When she emerged again, she crossed over to me.

"You awake, Danny?" Annalise asked the question with a smile that I didn't need to see to know was there. She knew I was awake, but gave me the courtesy of rhetoric.

"I am." I wished that I sounded sleepier.

"I'm going to head in a little early. I've got Adult Ed tonight and need to go over the lesson plan."

“Oh, right. Last class before winter break?”

She nodded and a strand of hair came loose, hanging across her left eye. She tucked it back in place behind her ear. “The last, yes. We may go out after. To celebrate. You should join.”

“Where?”

“Callahan’s.”

I wrinkled my nose. I wasn’t a fan of Irish pubs, and Annalise knew it. “Pass. But you have fun.”

She leaned down and kissed me gently. “I will. But not too late. It’s a school night, after all.”

My eyes drifted down to her breasts and how the sweater clung to them. “See you tonight.”

She saw where my attention was. “Uh huh,” she said. “Come out tonight if you change your mind. Love you.”

It was only after I heard the door open and close in our small apartment that it occurred to me—Jacque could be a student in her night class. In fact, the more I turned it over, the more convinced that I became. Had she mentioned him before? She talked about her students from time to time, but the stories all bled together.

Sleep was hopeless, so I climbed out of bed and took a shower. I let my mind wander. Annalise was a history nerd. Always had been. Teaching was a natural fit for her. She was nurturing, enthusiastic about what she did, and patient as hell. She loved it so much that she started teaching an adult education class for immigrants going through the naturalization process. She started last year, and actually enjoyed it more than she thought she would..

They actually love what they’re learning, she’d gushed with that first class. She’d also said that it was nice to work with adults, too, rather than disinterested teenagers.

Jacque, obviously, was a foreign name. I closed my eyes and thought of some French guy, tall and broad shouldered with a scruffy, artist look, hitting on Annalise. I imagined them chatting after class as the rest of the students gathered their things and left. She’d lean against the edge of her desk, her lesson plan clutched to her chest. He’d speak to her, standing just inside her personal space. He’d watch the way she watched him, her eyes on his lips as he spoke. A slight flush would climb into her cheeks as my heart climbed up my throat.

I was hard. My skin tingled as my stomach churned. I reached out and adjusted the water temperature from hot to cold. The icy spray flushed out my fucked up thoughts and I was once again under control by the time I stepped out.

Only I wasn't. I had a name. I needed to know more.

*

Things after Terrance were rough. I hadn't slipped out after walking in on them, and I've lost count of the number of times that I've wondered why I stayed. But I had stayed, standing there, rooted to the floor, and watched as Terrance finished inside of my girlfriend—my future wife.

"Danny!" she'd cried out when she spotted me. She scrambled to cover herself, to push Terrance away and get under the covers. Her eyes were wide, surprised, embarrassed.

So many emotions ran through me at that moment—too many to deal with at that moment—but above all was a sense of jealousy and betrayal. There I was, come to profess my love, and she was getting filled by some well-hung, black dude. It didn't matter that we had an agreement. It didn't matter that had I met some hot chick that night, I could have been doing the same. All that mattered was that she was, and I wasn't.

So I left. I don't think I even said anything. I just looked at them one last time, turned, and left.

When my blood finally had time to cool—and it took a really long time for it to cool—reason and rationality returned. We were never exclusive, and just because I thought that she was pure and virtuous while I slept around didn't mean that she was, or that that was wrong. She was only human, just like me. But more than that. She was...sexual. Just like I was.

This was a beginning. For me. For us. For the future we were now living. Ironically, I don't know that we'd still be together were it not for Terrance—not that he was invited to our wedding or anything. It was a crisis point that forced us to evaluate what we meant to each other.

Even more ironic was the reason that she was with him at all—according to her, anyway. She'd said that she came looking for me at the party, having come to a similar conclusion that I'd arrive at later that evening—that I was The One. She wanted to be with me. Apparently when

she arrived, she saw me flirting with some brunette. She'd left, upset and crying, when she bumped into Terrance. I guess he decided to comfort her.

I thought about that meeting a lot in those months after. I thought about a weeping Annalise bumping into Terrance on the dark, grassy quad. Thought of him collecting her into his arms, brushing tears from her eyes, leaning in and asking what was wrong...

It wasn't the first time that they'd hooked up. She swore that it was the last, though, but for a long time, I didn't believe her. I don't think I really wanted to. Sexuality is a crazy thing. It's never straightforward. That incident was a reminder of just how wild it was.

*

I didn't feel as refreshed as I would have liked as I stepped out of the shower, and when I discovered that we were out of coffee beans, things got worse. I groaned, threw on jeans and a sweater, and headed down to the corner coffeeshop.

We lived downtown, and I don't think I'll ever get tired of stepping out into the noise of the city. The morning was crisp beneath a steel gray sky that promised snow. The bundled commuters sensed it, heads down, their breath clouding around them as they hustled along the sidewalks. I threaded my way through them and got in line at the Java House and wondered why the hell I hadn't grabbed a coat.

"Merry Christmas, Danny," greeted the barista behind the bar. "Small coffee, dark blend?"

"Please and thank you, Stacy."

Stacy was cute in a hipster way. She had a tiny nose ring, a small series of tattoos along her forearm of a bird in flight, and in the cold of winter, usually wore a knit cap that made me think of artists. This morning, she wore a Santa hat that somehow made her even sexier. She looked like the kind of chick who'd do wild things to you in bed.

As always, when that thought popped into my head, a smile curled at Stacy's lips like she knew exactly what I was thinking. I felt heat rise up my neck, quickly fishing out my wallet to pay.

"No coat? Brave man," she said as she made change.

"Caffeine trumps comfort every day," I said.

“Then without delay...” She set a cup of coffee on the counter between us. “Have a nice day, Danny. I’ll be right here if you need me for anything else.”

I nodded, thanked her, and left.

Stacy was the kind of girl that I used to date before I met Annalise—fun girls who weren’t looking for anything serious, girls who’d perfected the art of flirting. Stacy knew exactly how to put it all out there without actually putting it all out there. If I wanted to invite her back to my place, I was near certain she’d tell me what time her shift ended.

Not that I’d ever do something like that—nor was I even tempted. But Stacy is a good foil to Annalise, and I’d always thought of them as distinctly different. I’d been attracted to Annalise for all kinds of reasons—she was a beautiful blonde with a glowing smile and a Southern lilt that killed me every time, but she was also sweet, kind, and intellectual in a way that most girls I dated were not. We actually talked about things, rather than just watch TV and have sex. So I put her in a different camp than the Stacys in my life.

Only Terrance shook that conceit—for a short time, anyway. Over the years, the sex-kitten version of my wife had faded. She’d gotten her Master’s in History at GW. She’d taken a job at a prep school for the kids of Congressmen and lobbyists, and had to deal with all the bullshit that that came with. She taught night school to adults who really wanted to learn, and now, potentially, she’d dreamt about one of them. Now, there was the possibility that she was going out to happy hour with him...and I’d declined to join her.

Had she invited me along because she needed a reminder to behave? No, of course not. Annalise wasn’t some animal driven by her baser needs, and yet...and yet that idea was so damn sexy.

Again, I thought about the barista at Java House. If it was Stacy out for drinks with a hot young guy who she’d been fantasizing about, would she hesitate if he made a pass at her? No. Is that what I hoped would happen with my wife?

It ate at me through the day. I did work...I think. I ate...I’m pretty sure. I oscillated between molten excitement and crippling panic. I was hard so much that it hurt. I put on shorts without boxers, despite the wintery season.

By the time Annalise texted me around nine, telling me that she was at the bar, I knew what I had to do. I went to go change out of my shorts.

3.

Callahan's was your typical Irish pub—too much dark green and maroon, Guinness and Harp on tap, menus with that cheesy, Old English block lettering that made them near illegible. The scene on a Thursday night was more crowded than I'd expected, which was a good thing because I could slip in without being seen.

Due to some roadwork being done, it took much longer for the cab to navigate the traffic—over a half hour. I found Annalise at the bar, standing out like a beacon in her white sweater and pants. I had no idea how long Annalise and her students had been here—it was close to 9:45 by the time I actually walked in the door—but class ended at 8:30, so it was possible that they'd been here for a while already. In fact, as I walked in, one of the guys was already putting on his coat and saying goodbye.

I watched her hug the man, wondering if he was Jacque. He looked like he could have been French, but was a little older than I'd expected. Did they hold the hug too long? When he pulled back, did their eyes linger?

Goodbye, he seemed to say before zipping up his coat and making his way towards the door. I studied Annalise, half-expecting her to watch the man wistfully as he left. She didn't. Instead, she turned back to the bar, and for a second, I thought that she was all alone. I started to make my way toward her when a guy took a couple pints of beer off the bar and handed one to her.

My heart froze as I watched Annalise accept it with a smile. The man said something, held his glass to hers in cheers. Both drank deeply, something that Annalise only ever did when she was nervous.

My mouth went dry. Was this Jacque? He didn't look anything like the man I was expecting, but then I was expecting a pale Frenchman, and the man who seemed to command my wife's attention was a tall, young, and black.

As I watched them talk, I found myself moving across the room, positioning myself so that Annalise's back was to me, but I could observe the two of them. And it really was just the two of them. I kept expecting some others to join from her class, but no one else did. They were in a

world of their own, and with each passing minute, my heart raced faster and faster.

She looked stunning, standing there with another man in the midst of all these strangers. Her hair was down, the pale locks flowing around her shoulders, and when she threw her head back and laughed at something he said, my heart fluttered.

As I watched them together, I ordered a beer without remembering that I had. Maybe it was because she had no idea that I was there, but she seemed so vibrant with him. He was a good looking man and was generous with his smiles, which brought them out in Annalise. His head was shaved other than a clipped goatee that emphasized the squareness of his jaw.

He carried himself with confidence. Many men grew shy around Annalise, talking to her like she was some kind of Hollywood starlet, rather than a normal person. Their voices would go up. They'd fail to maintain eye contact. Awkward silences would be filled with trivial chitchat. Not so with this guy. He spoke to her as an equal, not overbearing, but also not self-conscious. He made eye contact. He'd reach out and touch her arm to make a point—each gesture sending a jolt through me. He made her laugh.

Annalise didn't do anything to discourage it, although she didn't reciprocate. Instead, she'd brush her hair back, or touch her neck. When she half turned, I could see a blush climb in her cheeks, although that could have been from the booze. When the man leaned in and whispered something to her, she laughed once again, only this time, there was a sense of nervousness to it. She shook her head, then laughed again.

Before I knew it, my beer was empty and I had a decision to make. Do I keep watching and see if I could really, truly trust her? Do I text her and ask her where she was? Do I confront the two of them right now and demand to know what was going on?

Her companion said something to her that looked like, *Don't go anywhere*, then left toward the bathroom. I made my decision then, settling up my tab, pulling my coat back on like I'd just arrived, and crossing over to Annalise.

I'm not sure what I expected. Guilt, maybe? For Annalise to quickly sweep the bar to make sure there wasn't anything incriminating? Some indication that she'd been doing something she didn't think she should have with another man.

There was none of that. Instead, her face lit up when she saw me. “Danny, you came!” Then her eyes narrowed a little. “I thought you didn’t like Irish pubs? Did you forget to pay the cell phone bill again?”

“What? No! I just...we haven’t gone out in a while. Figured it was worth the cheese.” I looked around, like I really had just arrived. “Where’s the rest of your class?”

“You missed them! Well, all except Jacque.”

Jacque. Boom. So that *was* Jacque. Even without the sex dream, the guy made me nervous. The fact that she’d fantasized about him was like a bomb going off somewhere in the back of my brain.

“You okay, Danny?”

“Yeah, sorry.” I blinked. “What are you drinking?”

“Irish Car Bomb. Don’t judge!” Her cheeks were already warming before I could even smirk at her.

“No judgment here. It goes with this place.”

Her eyes shifted over my shoulder. Focusing on something, she licked her lips nervously and took a sharp breath before looking back at me. Or maybe I’d just imagined all that.

“Jacque, this is my husband, Danny,” she said before I even saw the man. Had she added emphasis on the words: *my husband*? Or was that me, again?

Jacque stepped into view, offering me a firm handshake. I met his eyes as we shook, trying to gauge his reaction. Was he upset that I’d shown up? Had I spoiled his evening?

“It’s nice to meet you, Danny.” Jacque had a resonant voice, his English accented with French, yet distinctly African.

“Nice to meet you, too.” That’s when I realized that I had no idea what else to talk to this guy about. “So you’re in Annalise’s class?”

It felt lame as soon as it emerged.

“I am. You are a lucky man. It’s a rare thing to find someone so passionate about history.” When he said *passionate*, he glanced at Annalise, and my chest tightened.

“Yes, she’s a very passionate woman.” I’m not sure why I said it—maybe it was the beer I drank too fast. Maybe the self-destructive urge that always accompanied this crazy fantasy of mine.

Jacque raised his eyebrows slightly, uncertain how to play this.

Annalise stepped in before he could, quickly changing the subject with a sharp look at me. “Jacque is from Sierra Leone. He’s been here, working as a photographer for...how long? About a year?”

A photographer. I could see that. He had that world-wary look to him, yet friendly enough to get him through some hairy situations. He said. “Yes, just about a year. I arrived on Christmas Day. Best day of my life, man. I love America.”

“Tell that to the guys running for president,” I said. “They seem to think that everything is broken.”

Jacque waved his hand. “That’s nothing. Politics are politics. This...” He glanced around the bar. “This is what’s real. There’s so much opportunity. You’ve got it good, friend. Back home...”

As he began to talk about his time back home

I wanted to not like him, but it was hard to be upset with a guy with that much exuberant optimism. I began to second guess myself. When I’d been watching him from across the room, I’d wanted to believe he was a brash womanizer who could look at Annalise’s ring and see a challenge, not a barrier. But maybe that’s just the way he was, smiling and animated. Maybe he really didn’t want to fuck my wife. He just enjoyed her company.

And yet there were those touches on her arm. There was the eye-contact. Even now, as I looked at Annalise as he talked about the American Dream and the hardships he had back at home, I could see...what? Adoration in her eyes? Attraction? She was a sucker for a sappy story. It’s why she took the night school job in the first place. Was that Jacque playing her? Or was he for real?

It didn’t hurt that he was a good looking guy. Up close, I could tell he was younger than us by a few years, fit and handsome. His shaved head shined as the lights of the bar played across it. I imagined Annalise’s slender fingers clutching it, pushing him down between her legs and—

“I need a drink,” I said, turning away from the two of them and pushing up to the bar.

Things had gotten crowded since I’d arrived, and I had to wait as the bartender worked through the crowd. Behind me, I heard Jacque and Annalise chat again without understanding what was being said. I did hear her giggles, though, and they sent waves of anxiety and excitement through me each time.

At last, I got my beer and turned back to them. Jacques stopped talking abruptly, smiling and nodding his head.

"Did I miss something?" I asked.

Annalise rolled her eyes. "Jacques here wants to buy us a round of shots. I told him that we all have work tomorrow, and that it would be completely irresponsible."

"Let's do it," I blurted.

Jacques grinned. "I like your husband," he said.

Annalise shook her head in disbelief. At least she was smiling. That was a good thing. "You know we're not in college anymore, right?"

I thought of Terrance all over again, my heart skipping. "Oh, I know."

Annalise flushed in a way that made me wonder if she was thinking the same thing.

"So yes?" Jacques asked, unable to read us.

"Fine," Annalise said. "But you're buying."

"Of course, teach," he said, taking up the spot I'd just vacated at the bar.

Annalise pulled me close and kissed me. "We're going to regret this tomorrow, you know."

"I do. But that's what sick days are for?"

"Doesn't exactly work that way in the school system."

"You'll be beautiful," I said.

Annalise giggled. "I don't need to be beautiful! I need to be alert enough to deal with a bunch of bored teenagers."

"Just wear something tight and low-cut and they won't notice at all."

"Gross," she laughed.

"Three shots of Jameson," Jacques said in a lot shorter a time than it took for me to get my beer. He handed us each a short glass and held his high. "A toast to the American Dream." He met Annalise's eyes, adding, "And all the passion that comes with it."

I nearly sputtered as I downed the burning whiskey. Tears came to my eyes as it ended in a fit of coughs. Jacques clapped me on my back. "Everything okay?"

"Yeah, yeah. Just...I haven't done a shot in forever."

"Practice makes perfect, yes? Another?"

I knew I shouldn't, which is probably why I agreed. "Let me get this round," I said. "Annalise?" I asked.

She waved her hand. "I'll pass. You boys go ahead."

I went back to the bar, vowing that this would be the last time. Again, I heard the two talk. Again, I heard her giggles. Only this time, I felt a little less jealousy and a lot more excitement. I knew where I fantasized a night like this could lead. I also knew that it never would. Still, the fantasy warmed me as I waited.

When I turned back, shots in hand, Jacque was whispering something into Annalise's ear. They were standing close enough to send a jolt through me. I was happy for the warm, alcoholic cocoon that surrounded me. Made seeing something like that easier to deal with.

"My turn to toast." I said, handing the shot glass to my new friend. "To my beautiful wife, Annalise."

"Cheers," Jacque said with a wide smile.

This time, the shot went down easier.

"Why don't you settle up, husband of mine?" Annalise said. "It's time to get out of here before someone has to carry you out."

Jacque sized me up. "I think I could manage."

Annalise laughed. "Don't you go on encouraging him. You've already done enough damage."

I settled up as she'd instructed, and suddenly it was time to go. We pulled on our winter coats and wrapped ourselves in our scarves. Annalise pulled on a white, woolen hat that made her look adorable with her faux fur lined coat.

"It's nice to meet you," Jacque said, once again offering me a firm handshake.

"Good to meet you, too, my man. Good luck, and congrats in advance on your year anniversary."

"Thank you." He turned to Annalise, offering his hand to her, too. When she took it, though, he held it for an extended time before he pulled her in for a warm hug. For a second, I imagined Annalise's pale, naked body pressed against Jacque's dark, brown skin, and felt butterflies in my gut. "Thank you for teaching me about American history. I'm going to miss our Tuesday and Thursday nights together."

Those butterflies went rabid. I stood there, buzzing hard as I watched these two lose themselves right in front of me.

"Oh, please, you know there's no grade for the class, right?"

Jacque kissed her on each cheek before stepping back. “*Joyeux Noël*, you two. Have a good night.”

4.

When he was gone, Annalise threaded her arms into mine. “You didn’t drive here, did you?”

“Cabbed.”

“Good, let’s go.”

Outside, the snow I’d felt in the air all day had finally begun to fall. We looked up, letting the flakes melt on our faces. “That’s beautiful,” Annalise said.

“So are you.”

She giggled and pulled me to the curb, holding her hand up for a taxi. “Jacque seemed nice,” I said, feeling the heaviness of the oncoming conversation. The two shots supplied a sense of inevitability to it.

“He’s a nice guy,” Annalise said without looking back at me.

“He’s got a thing for you, you know.”

She glanced back at me quickly before setting her eyes back on the street, scanning for cabs. “No, he’s like that with everyone.”

I stepped up beside her, wrapped my arms around her from behind. Snow had begun to catch in her loose, blond hair. “You’ve got a thing for him, too.”

She laughed. “You’re crazy.”

“Maybe, but I’m not wrong.”

She released a heavy breath and turned to me. “I don’t have a *thing* for him. I mean, he’s a nice guy and all. And, he’s...”

“Hot?” I offered.

“Not a bad guy to look at.”

“Hot,” I repeated.

Annalise ignored me. “But he’s my student.”

“Was.”

“And whatever, I’m married to you,” she said, adding, “And he knows all about you.”

“Interesting thing for you to add. If he didn’t know about me, should I have been concerned?”

“You can be infuriating, you know that?” She laughed and turned back to the street. This time, she successfully flagged a cab down.

I felt fuzzy as we got into the back, the effects of the alcohol were still building.

"It's okay if you like him, you know. I'm okay with it." That was as much for me as it was for her.

Annalise cozied up to me. "Okay."

The dream was back. Annalise's cries for Jacque mixing with her time with Terrance. *Jacque. Yes. Right there, big boy.*

My heart boomed in my ears. "It's okay if you want to do more," I said.

She turned and looked at me, her brow setting as she tried to puzzle me out. "What are you talking about?"

"I heard you this morning." My face burned, now that I'd finally admitted it.

"Still not following."

"You were dreaming of him. You called out his name."

"I did?" In the darkness of the cab, I couldn't tell if she was blushing, but I imagined that she was.

"You did. But like I said, it's okay." I felt like I was breathing under water. "It's pretty hot, actually. You've thought about it before, haven't you?"

For a moment, I wondered if she'd keep playing ignorant. But she'd been drinking, too, and finally gave me a sheepish smile and said, "Maybe."

"You sounded like you were enjoying yourself."

Annalise turned away, looking out the window. "Oh my God, can we be home yet?"

I reached out and touched the inside of her thigh. "Seriously."

Our eyes met in the window's reflection, and I swear her eyes were just as heavy-lidded as mine.

The cab made its final turn and pulled up to our building. She practically ran out of it as I settled up with the driver. He gave me a knowing grin, but mercifully kept his mouth shut.

Annalise was already inside the lobby when I exited, waiting for the elevator. It opened as I approached. She didn't wait for me before ducking inside.

I entered with the lightness that came from too much alcohol consumed too quickly. She stood in the back corner, her hands clasped in front of her, staring up at me through her long, blond hair.

“Hey there,” I said. “You live here, or visiting a friend?”

She giggled. “I live here.”

“I haven’t seen you around. You live alone?”

She rolled her eyes, then held up her left hand, showing off her rings.

“I live with my husband.”

“Well, that’s a shame,” I said. “He’s a lucky man.”

“He is.”

I stepped closer to her as she ran her eyes over me. “He home?”

“Not yet.”

“Shame,” I said. I cupped her face, feeling the smoothness of her cheek as I angled her for a kiss. “Invite me in and I’ll take care of you.”

The elevator chimed before our lips met. Annalise was clutching my coat, her breathing heavy. “I need you.”

“Let’s go.”

We stumbled down the hall, desperate to get into our apartment. I couldn’t wait. I pressed her against the door in the hall, kissing her hard. She met passion for passion, our tongues dancing together as we dreamed about her kissing others. That was what she was thinking, I thought—I hoped.

I fumbled for the keys. We practically fell inside, slamming the door shut as we battled with our coats. “So this is your place?” I asked. I collected her in my arms and kissed her again.

“Mine and my husband’s.”

“We should be quick before he gets home,” I said, reaching for the bottom of her sweater. She didn’t respond, although she did help me pull her top off. I kissed her neck as my hands found her tits, full and warm. I imagined what it would be like to see them for the first time—what it would be like for Jacques to feel them in his hands. It was sizzling.

“You’re so fucking hot,” I whispered against her ear.

She raked her fingers through my hair, but didn’t say anything. I kissed down her neck and down her chest. She wrapped her hands around my head as I buried my face in her soft cleavage. Grabbing her by the ass, I lifted her onto the console table we had in our foyer. Mail clattered to the floor. We didn’t care.

I worked open her white trousers. She helped, lifting her butt as I yanked them off her hips. I dropped to my knees, looking up at this

goddess, clad in nothing but her sexy, white lingerie. “Was this part of your dream?” I asked.

I didn’t wait for an answer—she wouldn’t have given me one, anyway. I just dove in, opening her legs and kissing across her thong-covered mound. She was so wet, her excitement heady and strong. Had Jacque gotten her there? Had our talk in the cab?

“Uh...” she sighed quietly as I pulled the thong aside and ran my tongue along her smooth slit. She was definitely engorged, her pink beginning to peek out like a blossoming flower. I pulled the thong wider, drinking in the entirety of her bald pussy. She’d shaved, just this morning, after her dream.

To prepare herself for Jacque? The idea was insane and unlikely and profoundly exciting all at once. If Jacque were here, in our front hallway, on his knees, what would he do when he saw this sight?

“Very sexy, Mrs. Doyle. This for me?”

Again, I didn’t give her a chance to answer. My tongue flashed across her pussy, working her clit as I pressed two fingers inside her moist channel. She squirmed above me, draping her long legs along my back and tightened her fingers in my hair. I chanced a look up at her. Her eyes were shut tight. Her mouth hung open. She was lost in a dream, a fantasy. Of another man? Of her hot, black student going down on her?

I drove her right up to the edge of orgasm, then yanked away. She cried out. “No!”

“Where’s your bedroom?” I shot back. “I need to fuck you.”

Her deep breath was shaky. “Why do you need a bedroom?”

It was not a thing Annalise normally said. It was exactly the right thing to say in this moment. When I stood, she even reached out and began to work off my belt. Together, we shoved my pants down enough that my cock sprang free. Annalise wrapped her hands around it, pulling me forward with an urgency that felt giddy.

We didn’t bother removing her thong. We just pushed it aside as I slid into her velvet embrace.

I sighed as I entered her. “Oh, that feels good.”

Annalise mewed, her hand curling around the back of my neck for stability. We hadn’t had sex out here in the hall, and it took a couple minutes to adjust to it. The console table creaked beneath us, striking the

wall as I began to fuck her faster. A part of me felt self-conscious at the sound—what if the neighbors heard? The rest of me thought: Let them!

Annalise seemed to be of the same mind, pressing her free hand against the wall to stop the rhythmic thunk. She didn't tell me to slow, though, as she tightened her legs around my waist.

"Think the neighbors will tell your husband about me?" I asked.

I wasn't sure if my question was to tease Annalise, or myself, but I nearly lost it when she squeezed her heels into my lower back and moaned. The idea turned her on!

I leaned close, lowering my voice. "I've wanted this all semester long. You've been such a tease, teach." I fucked her harder, spurred on by her heavy breathing. "You always look so sexy up there. Do you think about me, when you get dressed, knowing it was a school night?"

I thought about the way she'd deliberated this morning before selecting her clothes, and when she ran her fingernails down my back and moaned something like a yes, I felt my insides quiver.

I urged her to think about it more, letting my words flow freely. "You've thought about this before, haven't you? Me following you back to your place?"

This time, she didn't respond. She didn't have to. I felt her pussy tighten around my driving cock. Her breath caught. She pressed her head back into the wall and squeezed her legs around me.

"That's it, Mrs. Doyle. Come for me. Come for Jacques."

She couldn't keep her cries contained. She opened her mouth, shouting, "Yes! Uhh, yes!"

I saw them in that instant. I was standing at the door, a few feet back, having just walked in to find Jacques fucking my wife in the foyer. She was lost in her lust, lost in the feel of his strange, new cock and his fit, black body. The image ended me. I slammed into her one last time, hard enough to leave a dent in the wall, and exploded inside of her.

Our lips found one another in a wet, messy kiss. For a second, it was Jacques kissing Annalise in the fiery heat of orgasm. I felt it. Annalise lived it. Our bodies craved it.

Then the moment passed, leaving us panting hard and sweaty. I was just a guy standing in the hall with my jeans around my ankles. I hadn't even taken off my shirt. And all of a sudden, the things I'd said to her returned with embarrassing vengeance.

“Well, that was...interesting,” Annalise said.

I bit my lower lip, heat springing to my face. “Yeah...I’m not sure where that came from?”

“You sure about that? Seems like you’ve been thinking a lot about it.”

I pulled my pants back into place as Annalise grabbed her sweater and pulled it on. She didn’t bother with her pants, and I watched her thong-clad ass move beneath the white knit turtleneck as she went into the kitchen to get us some water.

The only thing illuminating the living room was our Christmas tree, glowing soft and white. This close to Christmas, the tree was brimming with wrapped presents of all shapes and sizes. I still hadn’t figured out what to get for Annalise, though, a small point of stress for me. Like always, I procrastinated again.

“So you going to tell me what that was all about?” Annalise asked me. She was leaning forward on the island counter, her glass of water empty.

“It was just...nothing,” I said. Annalise’s expression was flat. “I mean, just a thing I think about sometimes.”

“Me with Jacque?” She didn’t take her eyes off me. “No, couldn’t be. I don’t think I’ve mentioned him before. So you mean...” She raised her eyebrows. “Me and other men?”

I smiled through my teeth. “It’s just a fantasy.”

“So it’s true!” Then: “Really?”

“I mean, it’s just a... It’s really nothing.”

She said, “You know I would never—”

“I know. it’s just a...a thing.” Calling it a fantasy gave it too much weight.

She said, “And all I need is you, right? I have no complaints in that department.”

And yet, you dreamt about Jacque this morning. “I know.”

She stared at me like I was an enigma, a small smile forming on her pretty face. “Well, I’m going to take a shower. I promise you no other guys will be joining me.”

With a wink, she strolled into the bathroom, leaving me with the delectable sight of her bare ass one last time.

5.

When I got home Friday night, Annalise was arranging the presents beneath the tree. “We got a package from my parents. So all that’s missing now is...” She put a finger to her lips, as if thinking. “Oh yes, my gift from you.”

I grimaced. This happened every year. Annalise didn’t have a whole lot of hobbies—at least not ones that required *stuff*. She liked to run, but had all the running gear she needed. She liked to read, but already had a Kindle linked to the library and was more than happy with that selection. Household gifts like a new set of pots or a vacuum just seemed insulting, and our apartment was small enough that we already had enough art on the walls and on our shelves. Because of all of that, I never knew what to get her. Worse, Annalise knew this as well.

“It’s hard to get something for the girl who wants for nothing,” I said.

She kissed me, then shivering. “You’re cold.”

“You’re warm.” I hugged her close, and she wiggled out of my arms with a laugh.

“Pizza tonight?” she asked. She went back into the kitchen and filled a glass of water.

“Sure, sounds good.” I took off my jacket, hanging it in the closet as I watched her go to the Christmas tree and refill its basin. She wore a pair of black yoga pants that had me fixated on her ass. Beneath the lights of the tree, she was the only gift I’d ever need.

“You know,” I said, “it would be much more helpful if you gave me a wishlist.”

Annalise rose. “Only if you dress up like Santa and let me sit in your lap.”

I laughed. “That could be arranged.”

“You’re naughty,” she said. “But then, we learned that last night, didn’t we?”

I’d half-hoped that she’d forgotten about that. A part of me withered with shame.

Then, she looked at me brightly and added, “Too bad I can’t put Jacque on my wishlist.”

My breath caught. My chest tightened. Annalise studied me, the mischief back in her eyes. “I never should have told you about that,” I mumbled.

“Why not? Isn’t this more fun?” She grabbed her phone. “So, pepperoni?”

*

Could I give Jacque to my wife for Christmas? My initial thoughts were silly ones: Jacque posed beneath our tree in a pair of red boxers and a bow around his waist; Jacque jumping out of a giant, wrapped box; Jacque wrapped up like a Christmas mummy. Then there was the matter of how to even “gift” him. As visions of cloth soaked in chloroform and kidnapping played out, I started to abandon the idea entirely.

There was also the matter of Annalise. Even if I could get Jacque there without committing a range of felonies, she’d never go for it. Sure, she had a dream about him. Sure, she probably fantasized about him. But that didn’t mean she’d willingly jump into bed with him. Stacy from the coffee shop was cute, but just because I had that thought didn’t mean I’d ever do anything with her.

And yet, I couldn’t stop thinking about it. I couldn’t go ten minutes without imagining Annalise with Jacque—and not just having sex. I’d watched them at the bar, watched the way they’d laughed and carried on. That closeness snuck into my fantasy as well. The way Jacque made her smile. The way he turned her back into the young woman I’d first fallen in love with.

She’d probably never sleep with him, and the idea of me “gifting” him was preposterous, despite her suggestion, but I couldn’t help but think that had she not been married to me, things would have been different.

That’s when I figured out what to get her for Christmas. It was not a good idea, I’ll admit, and if I spent even a small amount of time considering it, I would have discarded the idea completely. So I didn’t think about it at all. I just went into it with mulish determination, finding exactly what I was looking for in the early hours of Saturday morning, when I should have been asleep at Annalise’s side.

The “gift” arrived just three days before Christmas, sitting in a small, padded envelope on the hallway table that we’d made love on last week. I

handled it like a hand grenade, and when Annalise looked up from the laptop, I jumped and nearly dropped it.

“That my gift?” she asked. The computer cast blue light on her pale face, giving her a look of mischief that was probably imagined. No way could she know what was in here.

“Maybe.”

She said, “Can I get a hint?”

“Nope.”

“Okay then. But I’m not going to let you in on the extra special Christmas surprise I’m getting you for Christmas.” She practically shook with giddiness, closing the laptop. “I must say, I’ve outdone myself this year.”

“I thought you already got me something.”

“Oh, I did. But this is *so* much better.”

I groaned. Now I needed to get her something else. “Is this what you do, now that school’s on break? Shop all day?”

“No, I look at porn, too,” she said. We laughed. No way that was true.

“So no hint?”

“Christmas is Friday. I think you can wait.”

6.

Jacque wasn't the first man since Terrance to stir up this fantasy. There had been a few other guys over the years, but I'd never let Annalise know that.

There had been Robert Elliot, a platonic friend from college who—I was convinced—was just waiting to swoop in and make a play for her as soon as I turned my back. Things had been particularly difficult with him after the Terrance incident, and when I wasn't getting paranoid about Annalise sneaking off with her black lover, I was terrified that Robert Elliot was there to help her out. It was a wonder that we made it through those first few months.

Of course, nothing ever happened with Robert—neither before nor after—and eventually he left our lives for law school and a life in Seattle or something. But when he was around, my fantasy had begun to coalesce. When I knew he was hanging out with Annalise, I got all twisted up—and not entirely in a bad way. My heart beat a little faster. My gut squirmed a lot more. But I was turned on, no doubt about it. Something had awoken in the dark corners of my mind after Terrance, and it wasn't going back to sleep.

There was a fellow teacher she had for a while—Jamal Adams. He was the math teacher in her student group, so they ended up doing a lot of activities together. She brought him up more than any of the other teachers, and while she may not have noticed, I certainly did. I looked him up on Facebook, not surprised to see the smart-looking black guy in his profile pic. Despite his glasses, there was nothing nerdy about him, and I could definitely see why Annalise was so fixated on him.

Now, I am self-aware enough to realize that the BBC thing—the *big black cock*—is kind of a racist fantasy, and I've always thought of myself as a progressive guy. Even in the infancy of this fantasy, the excitement that came on like a low-grade fever wasn't limited to just Annalise with black guys. But when I learned that he was of the African descent, it made everything feel a little more intense. I thought of the two of them, locked away in an empty classroom, fucking on her desk. I thought about the way her pale skin would look against Jamal's darker tones. The way she'd gnash her teeth and press her breasts against his.

She never worked late—it just wasn't a thing that she had to do as a history teacher. She never gave me a reason to worry that things had crossed the line with Jamal, but I fantasized anyway. I never actually met the man, and eventually he moved away, but there were others behind him—fixations for my fantasy to snag and grow on. Tony, Marcus, Brad, Marshall. The black guys always sizzled the most, and maybe I was imagining it, but Annalise seemed to brighten up more when she talked about those guys in particular.

But maybe I wasn't imagining a thing? Jacque was a reminder of that. Jacque and her dream and the way she'd flirted with him at the bar. And now... And now, the present I'd wrapped up beneath the tree taunted me.

I could barely keep my panic at bay. I could barely contain my excitement. Very confusing.

7.

“Merry Christmas, honey,” Annalise said as she handed me a wrapped gift.

Christmas morning had arrived swiftly. I eyed the small box I’d wrapped my gift in with a mixture of excitement and trepidation, then took the one Annalise was handing me.

“Didn’t you already get me the headphones?” I asked.

She looked at me mysteriously. “That was the thing you thought you wanted. This is the one you really want.”

“Oh...kay.”

“Just open it.” Was that...was that nervousness? Suddenly, the gift took on a new and tense feeling.

It was about the size of a shirt box, but slightly heavier. I shook it, but it made no sound. Annalise returned my smile before I began to unwrap the gold paper. Under was a flat box, black and unadorned, and etched in gold lettering in the center read: *Sandra Sims Photography*.

I glanced up at Annalise, who looked intense behind her smile. She nodded at me curtly. I pulled the lid off. My breath caught when I saw the first, matted photo, sitting inside the black, velvet lined interior. It was a black and white photo of Annalise wearing a white corset, stockings, and not much else. On the top picture, she was kneeling on an unmade bed with her back to the camera, her fingers laced through her pale locks, which glowed in what looked like morning light flooding around her.

“Merry Christmas, honey,” Annalise said. I could not believe my eyes. Annalise had given me boudoir photos? I looked at her and she laughed. “Keep going, Danny. There’s more.”

My hand shook as I pulled the top photo off. The second photo was similar to the first, only this time, she was facing the camera, her full tits spilling over the top of the corset. Her hair spilled around her shoulders in a meticulously arranged mess, and she wore this smouldering expression that was so not Annalise, yet so hot.

“When did you do this?” I asked as I moved on to the third. This one was a classic pose: Annalise on her side, her head supported by her elbow,

her knee draped over her lower leg to emphasize the sinuous lines of her body.

“Just a couple days ago,” she said, looking at the photos over my shoulder.

“Short notice,” I said, mesmerized by the photo.

“You have no idea what I had to do to line up the photographer. He did a great job capturing the light, though, didn’t he?”

Didn’t *he*. *He*. It strummed through me like a chord.

Each photo outdid the one before it. Her corset was gone in the fourth, and she presented her naked back to my hungry eyes, wearing nothing but a thong. In the fifth, only her blond hair covered her breasts, and in the third, she didn’t even bother with that.

“Topless?” I asked, tearing my eyes away from the photo.

Annalise’s blue eyes danced. “Not just topless.”

My heart skipped. “Really?”

Her tongue danced at the tip of her lips. She looked back at the box. “Keep going.”

It felt like I was like paging through a Playboy for the first time. Everything was pressurized. I could feel my pulse thick in my veins as I pulled each, matted photo to reveal even more of my wife—again with her back to the camera, this time with one thumb pulling the thong off her hip; the next with no thong at all, her sweet, unblemished body completely nude from behind.

He. The photographer was a he. A snippet of Jacque’s introduction returned. *Jacque’s been here as a photographer for how long? A year?*

A photographer...

I ran my eyes along the photo of Annalise’s naked back, imagining Jacque doing the same through the lense of his camera. I imagined him setting it down as she looked over her shoulder. Their eyes would meet. She’d smile just enough to imply invitation. He’d pull his shirt off, and—

“You like that one?” Annalise whispered, drawing me from my fantasy. “What are you thinking about?”

“Um...nothing,” I said. I pulled the photo off, and it stole what remaining breath I had. “Wow.”

In the photo, she was leaning against a doorframe, her pose casual, like she was taking a break. Only she wasn’t. Only she was completely naked, her pinup body exposed. I studied it all, from the way her breasts hung,

round and ripe and capped with hardened nipples to the gentle roll of her hips and her perfectly smooth mound. I studied every detail of the photo, yet it was her smile that I kept coming back to. She wasn't nervous. She wasn't self-conscious or shameful in her nudity. She looked totally comfortable.

And all I could think about was who was she so comfortable with? Who was on the other side of this camera, putting her at ease? I knew who I wanted it to be, too, even as it scared me to death.

I pulled the photo out, steeling myself for what came next, ready for *anything*, and...was met by nothing but the black bottom of the box. That was the last one. Relief flooded through me, but also, deeply, disappointment. The show was over. Nothing left to see.

I looked over at Annalise, embarrassed by my conflicted emotions, only to see her with another present in her hands. My present. The present that I'd been fretting over since I ordered it.

"Now, I want to find out what this is," she said.

Every muscle in my body constricted. The boudoir photos had made me forget all about my own gift. My mouth went dry as she slid a finger beneath the wrapping and neatly tore it open. She pulled the top off and deftly drew out the card.

Heat flashed through me. "It's..."

"*One free pass*," she read, continuing to smile. She turned the matte black card over. "*One night with any man you choose, no questions asked. No repercussions.*"

Thank goodness for the Internet and the anonymity that came with it. I could only imagine the looks I'd get walking into a Things Remembered with that request.

"You said..." I could barely speak through the burning sensation in my body. "You said that you wanted Jacques for Christmas..."

She stared at me quietly a moment longer, the smile never wavering. Not even a fraction. She raised a brow. "You wish there were more photos, don't you?"

I wanted to lie. I wanted to deny. But she held a card that forced me to tell the truth. Even still, actually admitting it was like stepping out into the great, big, wild unknown. "Yes."

Her eyes glittered, just for a moment, before she reached behind her and handed me a second present, wrapped identically to her first.

“Well, how about a little Christmas magic.”

8.

Annalise wrapped her arms around me from behind, crushing her breasts against my back, as she watched my hands wrestle with the bow. She still wore her flannel pajamas, and her body was warm against my own.

“Who was the photographer?” I asked. My insides were tied up so tightly that it was hard to breathe.

“A friend doing me a favor,” she whispered.

“Jacque?”

“Is that what you’re hoping for?”

Yes! It was. But also, how could she know? I ignored the question and opened the box.

The first photo sent my entire world listing to one side. If I hadn’t been sitting, I would have fallen. The photo was a closeup of one of Annalise’s breasts, full and pale and beautiful, and cupped around it was a dark-skinned man’s hand.

“Yes, that’s Jacque’s hand,” Annalise said behind me. Her hand moved down between my legs, finding my cock hard through my pajamas. “He has such nice, big hands, and a good firm grip.”

This felt like a dream. This couldn’t actually be my wife, could it? She wouldn’t actually have let another man touch her like this without first talking to me, right? I expected that these photos were from Jacque’s portfolio, the model just someone with a passing resemblance to my wife.

And at the same time, I really, *really* wanted this to be her.

Annalise squeezed my hardon. “Keep going. It gets better.”

I did as I was told, half expecting a photo of her winking, as if saying, *You didn’t really believe that was me?* That photo did not emerge. At first, I didn’t even know what I was looking at. The shot was another tight one and at first, all I saw were shades of light gray on darker gray, with a scrap of lace along the left side. The picture resolved itself slowly. A hip. The smooth plane of a lower belly. The delicate pair of panties. And Jacque’s thumb fingering the lacy edge.

“So you want to hear what happened?” Annalise asked.

I couldn’t speak, so I just nodded silently.

“I knew that I wanted to do those photos for you for a long time. You’ve mentioned wanting that before. I just needed to work up the courage to do it.”

Okay, I thought. Or maybe I said it aloud. I don’t know. I turned over the next photo. This one was of two bodies together, hips pressed to hips, one dark and muscular, the other willowy and pale. They wore underwear—Annalise had her thong on, Jacques wore a pair of stark, white boxer-briefs, but I had a feeling that wouldn’t last. Annalise’s hand was grasping Jacques’s ass, and there, unmistakably, was her engagement ring. If this was a fake, that it was an incredibly elaborate one.

“I knew that Jacques sometimes did this on the side, but I wasn’t about to ask my student—and I wasn’t sure how you’d feel about me taking my clothes off in front of another man.” She pushed her hand inside my boxers, wrapping her fingers around my erection. “Last week, at happy hour, you cleared that up for me.”

“Annalise...” I groaned, finding my voice.

“Next photo. Go for it.” She moved around me, lowering her head into my lap as she fished out my cock. I unveiled the next photo just as her lips swallowed me into her mouth. I groaned, rocking my head back to stare at the ceiling, the photo seared onto the backs of my eyelids.

Another close up, this one of Jacques’s thick, dark cock and Annalise’s white hand wrapped around it—her left hand, her ringed hand. It looked huge.

She pulled her head back, but continued to pump me with her hand. “When I set it up, I fully intended for it to be just me. You know, I’d take some racy shots, and tease you a little before telling you nothing actually happened.” She glanced over at the open box of photos. “But then stuff actually happened.”

I moved on to the next photo, uncertainty and rabid anticipation sending tremors through me. Annalise watched, too, smiling as though remembering a fond memory. The photo was about as tasteful a shot of a blowjob as possible. It was taken from Jacques’s perspective, pointed down and slightly akimbo. Annalise’s eyes were cropped out, leaving just her nose and lips in the frame, along with half of Jacques’s hard cock, glistening with saliva. The way she sucked drew out her cheekbones. I’d never seen something so erotic be so beautiful.

“That was a good time,” she said, returning to my cock. I watched her cheeks cave with each suck, glancing at the photo, then back again. She opened her eyes to glance up at me through her long lashes. Had she done that with him? Had she fucked him with her eyes as she blew him? Of course she had.

Next photo was the same angle, only his cock was free and nuzzled into her cleavage. My breath caught. She’d fucked him there—a thing she’d only done to me a handful of times. It just felt so dirty from such a sweet woman, yet it has always been hot.

I flipped to the next photo. Another blowjob shot, this one in the mirror, Annalise’s naked body from behind, on her knees, her long blond hair sweeping down her back. Jacque was naked, too, cropped enough to hide the camera and his face, but revealing the expanse of his worked body.

“Did you...?”

I couldn’t even ask. I flipped instead, hoping to see evidence. A closeup of Annalise’s face now, tipped back, her eyes closed and covered in the honey of her hair. Next, closer still, just her mouth, her clenched teeth.

She pulled away, sensing my impending orgasm. “Did I have sex with Jacque?” she said.

She crawled up onto me, kissed me passionately. She felt like she was on fire on my arms. She pushed me into my back, the wrapping paper crumpling beneath us.

“The shoot was one of the sexiest experiences I’ve ever had. He’s good at what he does, putting me at ease, even though I was...” She trailed off, and I found the moment of modesty so endearing.

I found my voice. “It didn’t help that you had a crush on him.”

She pressed her pussy against mine, hot through the thinness of her pajamas. “Are you kidding? That made it even harder.”

“Looks like you got over that.”

Annalise’s smile was the same one that she had in the last photo of her first set: nude, comfortable, leaning against the doorway. “Like I said, he was very good at putting me at ease.”

She pulled her pajama top off, freeing her magnificent swells. I filled my hands with them, and when I did, I thought of the photo where Jacque did the same.

“We did most of the photos from the first set I gave you before anything happened.” Off went her pajama bottoms. When she ran her pussy

along my shaft, she was soaked and slippery. She teased me like that a couple times before adjusting the angle and sinking down. “Yes, that feels so good,” she sighed.

“How did it actually happen?” I said, fighting the urge just to come immediately.

“It was when I was down to just my panties,” she said. “He’d been adjusting me throughout, you know? The way my hair fell across my face or over my shoulders. The angle of my head, the jut of my chin.”

Jealousy and excitement coursed through me as I pictured all those little touches.

“He came over to fix my hair...” She bent down, bringing her lips within inches of mine. “Our lips were this close.”

I stared at her pouting, pink lips—soft, moist.

“I don’t know who moved first, but the next thing I knew, we were making out.”

I groaned, growing inside of her.

She added, “Like, really kissing. Like teenagers.”

And then we were kissing like teenagers, deep and uninhibited. I ran my hands over her body, over the curves captured like artwork in those photos.

She pulled out of the nosedive of a kiss, slightly out of breath. “Like it was a whim, he reached out, cupped my breast, and took a photo.” She shut her eyes and shook her head. “It felt so wrong. Yet so...amazing.”

“Looked amazing.”

Annalise opened her eyes, seriousness mixed in with her passion. She hesitated. My stomach cratered, and I didn’t know why.

“What?” I asked.

“I saw you when you walked in on me and Terrance. Back in college.”

“I know—”

“No, I saw you as soon as you walked in. I pretended that I didn’t. That I was caught up in the moment. But I knew you were there. And...and it was so sexy. I...liked that you watched.” She kissed me gently, apology in her furrowed brow. “When I heard Jacque’s shutter, I felt the same excitement.”

“You’re an exhibitionist,” I said.

“No...well, maybe, but for you.”

I shook my head. “I don’t understand.”

“I love the idea that you would get to see the photos later. I was so hot, all session long, but the idea that I’d actually get to fulfill your fantasy on camera was a total rush.”

Something nagged at me, but I was too caught up in the whirlwind of her story and the feeling of her body as it moved over me.

“We fooled around after that, between sets. He’d snap some shots of me in various, sexy poses, and we’d make out some more.”

“Just make out?” The question was rhetorical, but I craved an answer.

“I sucked his cock.”

The confession was as electrifying as I’d hoped.

“I fucked him.”

Things went white, like I’d been struck by lightning, like I’d died and gone to some fucked up place where you can feel a hundred conflicting things at once. I thrust up into her, my fingers tightening on her hips, and came with every last scrap of energy I had left.

9.

“How did you know?” I asked, once I was capable of asking anything.

The sweat was still warm on our naked skin, but that would soon give way to the cooler reality of our drafty apartment. A metaphor? Maybe.

“I was wondering when you were going to ask that,” Annalise said with a knowing smile. “I’m not the only one who talks in her sleep, you know.”

She giggled at my surprise. “What did I say?”

“Oh, quite a lot. Over the years.”

“Years?” I asked.

“Yeah. I pieced it together. You like the idea of me with other men.”

“Like what did I say?” My mouth was dry.

“Oh, mostly nonsensical things. At first, anyway, before I figured out your fantasy. You’d say things like, *You were with him, weren’t you?* Or, *You came home late last night. You have something to tell me?* At first, you mostly talked about Terrance, and I thought you were still mad at me.”

“I wasn’t. We got over that,” I said.

“I know. But at the time, I thought it was your subconscious, you know, not letting it go.”

I put myself in her shoes. It made sense. “I guess I didn’t let go. Just not the way you thought.”

“Yeah. Eventually I figured that part out. Especially when you started mentioning other guys. Guys I worked with. Or knew around. And I’d watch you carefully when I mentioned them after. You always had this edge. Could have been jealousy, but I know you better than that.”

“So why didn’t you say anything?”

“Why didn’t you?” she answered. It wasn’t harsh, she didn’t throw it in my face, but I knew she was right. She went on. “So I decided to give you a little more to think about last Thursday morning.”

My mouth hung open. “The dream? You faked it?”

“Well, not exactly. I really did have a sex dream about Jacque.” She giggled when my flaccid cock, still buried inside of her, stiffened. “I just vocalized it a little more when it woke me up.”

“And happy hour?”

“Well, I was hoping that you’d come. And when I saw you enter and hide over in the corner to watch...well, that was fun, too.”

“You saw me?”

Annalise laughed. “You’re not nearly as sneaky as you think you are.”

“And apparently you’re way sneakier than I ever thought.”

She bent low and said in her most husky voice, “That’s what all my lovers say, too.”

My cock came to life again, expanding inside of her. “Annalise...”

“Sorry, I only have one lover.” She kissed me. “Plus you.”

We made out again. Annalise slowly pumped me, coaxing me back to full extension. “You know, there are a couple more photos in there.”

The photos. I’d almost forgotten. She pushed herself back up to a straddle over me and reached for the box. I couldn’t help myself, running my hand up the side of her ribcage and over one of her soft swells.

“Jacque was a great kisser,” Annalise said, studying the photo in her hand without showing it to me. “And he smelled so good.”

She turned the picture, angling it down so I could look. It was another closeup, focused on their lips as they shared a deep kiss. I could just make out the way her tongue was pressed into his mouth. My stomach fluttered. I could feel their passion.

“You like that, don’t you?” Annalise said, feeling me grow harder still inside of her. “You know, even with the dreams and my theories, I would never have done anything with another man, don’t you? I don’t need anyone else but you.”

She set the photo down. Our eyes met. “But you did,” I said, more force behind the statement than I was expecting.

“I did, because of this.” She held up the black gift card. My gift to her. “I always thought it was just some harmless fantasy, you know? Something you thought about, but never really wanted.”

“But I just gave that to you.”

Annalise smiled. “You really need to be more careful. You left your browser open. I didn’t mean to look, I promise. But it was just there. “*One free pass. One night with any man you choose, no questions asked. No repercussions.* There’s no mincing words there. You took all the ambiguity out.”

“How do you know it was for you?” I challenged, but it was weak. She was right. This is what I wanted, and if I was honest with myself, I loved

that she'd taken the initiative.

"It wasn't for me?" Her eyebrows rose as she asked it. She bit her lip, contemplated something, then nodded. She started closing up the box of photos. "Then you really don't want to see this last picture."

"No!"

Annalise giggled. "It's pretty dirty."

"Please."

"We can always pretend that none of this actually happened." She was smiling. I was smiling. "But you don't want to do that, do you?"

"No."

She pulled the last photo out, but stopped just before turning it around. "I won't lie, I had a lot of fun taking these photos. But this, right here, showing you? It's like ten thousand times as fun."

"You're incredible, you know that?"

"Remember that after you look at this next photo."

"Stop the tease!"

Annalise giggled. "Sorry, sorry. Ready?"

"Yes!"

She turned it. I knew what it was going to be. I knew this was the explicit act, the crossing of the line. One that would change us. It was as lewd as it was beautiful, art in raw form, although not the close-up porn shot I was expecting. Instead, the angle was wide, pulled back enough to catch the couple in profile. Annalise was on her back, her legs spread wide as Jacque loomed over her. The muscles in his arms strained as he held himself up, his black skin glistening with perspiration. Annalise's head was tipped back, her blond hair pooling in the pillow beneath her. The lighting was dramatic, the moment real. She was coming...with another man buried inside of her.

The moment brought me back to Terrance, to that moment when I'd walked in. I heard her moans. Her hard breathing. *Fuck me, big boy.*

I didn't realize how short of breath I was until I tried to speak. "How was he?"

"Big," Annalise said. "Different."

"Good?"

"Very." She started fucking me faster, rolling her hips along me.

"Did you come?"

"I'm coming in that photo."

“How many times?”

Her hair was plastered to her forehead. She smiled. “I lost count.”

“Do you want to do it again?”

She didn’t answer immediately. Was it guilt holding her back? Was it fear? “Yes,” she said at last. “But...next time, you need to be there.”

I groaned, feeling my balls tighten one last time.

“I want you to watch me.”

“Yes,” I hissed.

“I *need* you to watch me.”

“Oh, Annalise!”

“Oh, Danny...” she sighed. I came as she swept her hands along my face and neck. As she kissed my neck. As she lifted her lips to me ear and whispered, “Merry Christmas.”

About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter). I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.

Also by Kenny Wright

After School Special (A Short)
All In: Strip Poker Done Right
Because He's Watching; Ian's Obsession
Cool With Her
Dreaming of Another
Eight Hundred Dollar Heels (A Short)
Just Watch Me
Leap
Moving Mrs. Mitchell (A Short)
Naughty But Nice (A Short)
Nothing Forbidden
Rediscovering Danielle (A Short)
Something Forbidden
Training to Love It
Training to Love It 2
Unconventional: Business or Pleasure
Wife Watching Shorts, Vol. 1
The Woman She Was (A Short)
While She Watches

In collaboration with Ben Boswell:

Parallel Lines Part 1
Parallel Lines: Part 2

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